On Being Transgender

By Ethan Smith and Miles Walser

INTRODUCTION

*Ethan Smith, born Emily Smith and Miles Walser, born Lillian Olivia Walser are two talented spoken-word poets who are both dealing with the same issue: living the life of a transgender male. Imagine being born into a body that feels alien to you. Imagine struggling every day to pretend to be something your body says you **are**, but your mind says you're **not**.*

Acceptance of people regardless of race, religion, country of origin or even gender identification has been and still is a series of small but steady steps. Listen to the emotions trapped inside two amazing people. We begin with Ethan Smith's "Letter to the Girl I Used to Be."

A Letter to the Girl I Used to Be by Ethan Smith

Dear Emily,
Every time I watch baseball, a voice I no longer
recognize whispers:
"Ethan, do you remember when you were going to be
the first girl
To play in the major league Seattle mariners rally cap?"
But to be honest, Emily, I don't.
Dad told me that like it was someone else's bedtime
story
But I **do** know you had that drive . . .

The year you turned 11
Was the first time you said out loud that you didn't
want to live anymore
In therapy you said you wouldn't make it to 21.
On my 21st birthday I thought about you.
You were right.
At 19 you started to fade.
I tried to cross you out like a line in my memoir
I wished I could erase completely
And maybe I'm misunderstanding the definition of
death,
But even though parts of you still exist,
You are not here.
Most of my friends have never heard your name
until now.

I've been trying to write this letter for 6 months.
I still can't decide if it should be an apology or not.
But now you will never hear "Emily Smith" announced
at a college graduation
Get married, give birth.
When the prescribed testosterone started taking
effect,
my body stopped producing the potential for new life.
Every month I thought about your children,

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how I wanted them too.
I let a doctor remove your breasts so I could stand up straighter
Now, even if I somehow had those children, I wouldn't be able to nourish them
My body is obsolete
Scarred cosmetic, but never C-section.

I was 4 days late
They will never be grandparents
I was 2 weeks late
They will never learn to jump rope
I was 3 weeks late
They will never shout "Watch mummy, watch me on the slide"
I was 2 months late
A piece of us will never wrap their arms around our legs for comfort
Just to keep them from falling down.

And I am sorry that this process is so slow, and all you can do is wonder if you ever had a place.
You did.
You still do.
Don't forget that

Yours, Ethan

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P.S. I never hated you

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Ethan Smith quoted in text by Diana Bruk
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TRANSITION

An apology to yourself for accepting your gender identity – Just imagine. But it's even more than that . . . with personal anguish comes pressure from society as well. The fear of acceptance. The fear for your personal safety. Nebraska by Miles Walser

Nebraska by Miles Walser

For years you cut your hair short, lowered your voice,
collected ace bandages and baggy clothes.
Small town talk stuck to your shoulders,
you nervously shuffled around gas stations,
never looked men in the eyes.
We share unwanted wombs.
While mine collects cobwebs,
yours lies in a coffin in Nebraska.

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This is the state that made you famous,
handed movie scripts to Hilary Swank.
Your murder was Oscar worthy.
We are walking obituaries.
Your hate crime headline already
carved across my forehead.

Brother, I'm afraid to use the bathroom…
(Walk in, head down, don't look at another guy.)
I'm afraid I'll be discovered…
(Don't talk, don't stare.)
Some thick armed man will call me a queer,
tell me to show him my . . . .
Suddenly I'm thrown against faucets,
spit in my face, work boot gutting my stomach.
I see you on the movie screen
and wonder if it's my reflection.
I watch them push you into the dirt
and drag me into their car
as they break our bodies in between our thighs.

Brother, did it hurt when you kissed her goodbye?
Did you know you were breaking your promise
when you told her you'd come back?
Did your parents panic?
Buy you a prom dress?

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Struggle over pronouns at family gatherings?
And how long did it take your girlfriend
to run her hands along your skin, soft as hers?
Did she leave her eyes open?

We are carcasses.
We are public secrets,
playground jokes, and horror films.
We are costumes, stuffing, binding and makeup.
We aren't real men to them.
Invisible 'til we're screaming.
They don't remember our names
until they read them on our tombstones.

They exposed you.
Decided you're better off as
splattered ink on newspaper.
Used you as a warning for the rest of us.
And there are days when it works.
Sometimes . . .
I forget that sidewalks can be safe.
Sometimes . . .
I confuse their shooting eyes for the bullet that met
yours.
Sometimes . . .
I imagine the phone call my mother would get.
Can almost hear my sobbing friends.

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Smell the lilies on my casket.
But brother, I am trying to be brave.

TRANSITION

Miles dedicated that poem to Brandon Teena, a transman who was raped and murdered in Humboldt, Nebraska along with two others.

So if you survive the personal anguish and aren't attacked by society – what comes next? A relationship . . . love . . . again, the prospects are difficult, to say the least – We Eat an Apple in My Bed by Miles Walser

We Eat an Apple in My Bed by Miles Walser

We've been kissing for months.
Three times a week our toothbrushes
share a chipped porcelain mug in my bathroom.
As my lips reach for the juice falling from her laugh,
her mom calls.
I listen as she talks about Biology, her new job,
asks about her sister.
Her eyes drop as she whispers,
No, I still don't have a boyfriend.
On cue, I stop chewing.
She looks at me, waiting for my face to flush,
for me to tear from the bed,

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but I won't get mad at her.
She shouldn't have to explain
why we can't go swimming in public,
why I don't own a razor,
why she doesn't need to buy birth control.
She hangs up the phone; I pick up the fruit,
tell her
Apparently, there's a tiny amount of cyanide in apple seeds.
She shrugs, says she can handle a little danger,
but I've studied how her dimples disappear
when she lies,
and I know she's thinking about a man
she could parade around her family,
who could kiss her scratchy with stubble.
The kind of man I'll never be.

She squeezes my hand in the movie theater dark
but tosses it to the side in front of her friends.
Says she just needs time.
She walks on the sidewalk.
I walk in the street.
She closes the door.
I kiss it goodnight.
She goes home for Thanksgiving.
I promise not to call.

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If I were a postcard, she could hide me in her pocket.
If I were clay, she could mold my body
    into something easier to love.

She kisses down my neck,
my peel hiding the rotten fruit inside me.
As I tell her about the cyanide,
her head resting on my chest,
she talks about cider, autumn pies.
See, she says, *Apples are harmless.*

But she saves the last bites for me,
scared to let her lips wander
too close to the core.

SOURCE INFORMATION

For Nebraska and We Eat an Apple in My Bed
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TRANSITION

Unlike our first author who mourns the loss of motherhood . . . Miles Walser looks to a future when he will one day become a dad. Lillian by Miles Walser

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Lillian by Miles Walser

I will name you Lillian
because to me it sounds like running through a garden
and with every step you take in life
I want you to feel as beautiful as the flower I'll call you.
And don't worry about your mother:
whenever I meet her,
I'll convince her I deserve naming rights.

But more importantly, Lillian,
you will inherit from me the one thing
the world will let me give you.
I can't hand you my curly hair or blue eyes,
so you will have the name that has followed me
from birth certificate to driver's license to passport,
all the while knowing it was never really mine.

Your middle name will be Olivia.
For years I hated the name;
it burned through the paper of any official document I
    filled out,
seared my ears when it escaped the tongue of a
    stranger,
and annihilated my entire body anytime I had to
incorrectly introduce myself.

But Lillian, I understand what happened now.
See, I am just the middleman; the accidental address on

the package.
The name was given to me, to hold onto for you,
my future daughter.

For you I keep it safe,
protected from people who gawk at me,
not understanding why my short hair and masculine appearance
can't match the sweet femininity in the name.
Or people who do understand and hate me for it,
attacking the way I bypass the barrier of biological sex
because I know that what I feel is more important
than what I see in the mirror.
And people who think I should conform to the name I was given,
ignoring everything I know about myself,
the same people who will someday hate our family
because of me.

But through it all, Lillian,
always remember that I love you.
I've never met you,
but I love you.
My future daughter.

So I hold the name under my shirt, against my chest,
and with every heartbeat the syllables provide me
a new sense of rhythmic direction.
Because I know I'm moving towards you.

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The name Olivia no longer hides in the back of my throat
but floats off my tongue.
A promise of beauty; a promise of purpose.
A promise of you,
my future daughter.

Someday, Lillian Olivia, after you've mastered the art of the two-wheeled bike,
I'll take you to the top of the tallest hill in town and we'll soar down,
secretly wishing we could take off into the rushing wind
and at the bottom I'll tell you that
that feeling was how your father felt,
knowing someday, you'd be in his world.
And he'd finally get to give you your name.

SOURCE INFORMATION

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